Next steps and future analysis

November 4, 2026

Notes USC Brownbag

homas: studying preference for redistribution is over, the gap is more interesting, the evolution of the gap is even more interesting.

Zero-sum: are our variables strictly zero sum — or as they capture that the game is rigged ("need to be wealthy to get ahead" (ANES or GSS)

Formative growth years are not good — (1) they are not robust to age or cohort or demean (2) we claim that economics is not the main driver in zero sum

Absolute Mobility

Alternative: Real Estate Measure to Capture cost of entering the housing ladder / measure of consumer sentiments / anything that suggest the game is rigged.

Paola suggests a paper by Pons and an other by a UCLA grad student Turek.

Age - Period - Cohort problem. that we look at change in various point in the age distribution could help us here (to be discuss) basically it is a rotation at the bottom

Assume three generation (a,b,c) living two period and born at t-1,t,t+1

Gap(t+1)-(t)= [c(t+1)-b(t)] - [b(t-1)-a(t)]

the data suggest that the second term is near zero so the action is on the front end.

@Niclas could you trade the decomposition (we have more that three groups) but the same logic applies

Next steps

- Start drafting; sequence findings; make slides
- Re-read literature for core findings about age/beliefs/redistribution to position Prolific survey and the broader project; edit lit review
- Investigate drivers of the belief shift
  - Timing: old moved around 1990, young moved strongly around 2020–2024.
  - State/local U.S. data to test causal effect of age inequality in economic conditions and political representation.

    - Text data (Congressional speeches, Manifesto project) to test supply of attribution/zero-sum rich/race political narratives. Can classify messages according to Narrative Policy Framework, setting-villain-victim.
- Draft/pre-register 2nd Prolific wave
    - An information provision or wording experiment generating exogenous belief variation. See if/how preferences move.
    - A more comprehensive questionnaire pairing existing questions with Haidt's values, govt. trust, religiosity, and race-related beliefs.
    - In-depth measurement and differentiation of zero-sum/attribution beliefs.

Prolific 2nd wave

Running list of questions that could be useful in a second wave.

Must-have:

- Priming or wording or information treatment
    - To shift beliefs about the economic game/zero-sum. Even to generate income/path uncertainty?
- Decomposition of zero-sum wealth/rich/competition
    - Fixed-pie vs. scarce positions/resources vs. ...
- Distinguish between zero-sum and deservingness/attribution
    - Zero-sum: how the income distribution changes in response to someone's personal effort or gains. Deservingness: whether those who benefit from an income draw or program are seen as responsible for their situation.
- Why someone becomes wealthy
    - (i) effort, investment, risk-taking, innovation (ii) structural advantages, rich family (iii) luck.
    - Structural advantages questions seem highly significant in other surveys, especially if concrete examples are mentioned. Run a battery of advantages: education, race, wealth, connections, etc.
- Why someone becomes poor
    - Because they are lazy or unlucky?
- What income should track
    - (i) effort, time, responsibility, seniority (ii) skills, intelligence, credentials, investment (iii) performance.
- Zero-sum race/disadvantaged
    - More about minorities or poorer groups or forced equity. DEI is attached to gender, sexual identity, etc.
- Racism and discrimination

- Perceived conflict/antagonism between rich and poor
- Deeper questions about whether/why one's beliefs changed
  - Asking about zero-sum, incentive, and mobility beliefs, not just redistributive preferences.
- Reasons for supporting/opposing redistribution in their own words
  - Easier to extract insights from free-response questions with LLMs.
- Missing values/beliefs questions
  - Religiosity (importance in life, attendance), social class (self-reported), opinions on immigration, trust/confidence in government (including capacity/capability), generalized social trust, political/civic involvement.
- Missing economic/demographic information
  - Health insurance coverage, homeownership, wealth and previous income, retirement status and benefits.
- Remove policy from question stem as much as possible
  - Especially for gapmotivates and taxdemotivates.
- MFT/Haidt moral values
  - Care/compassion, proportionality, equality, obligation/authority, loyalty, purity/sanctity

Nice to have:

- Precise measurement of generosity
  - Separate it from universalism, scale with income if numeric.
- Decomposition of mobility beliefs
  - Absolute vs. relative mobility. Personal mobility: I or people like me can/can't move up. Structural mobility: origins do/don't constrain outcomes. Meritocratic mobility: moving up is/isn't based on talent or providing value.
- Separate individual vs aggregate incentive effects
  - The distinction seems to matter in Stantcheva 2021.
- More-precise questions about financial expectations, income/wealth variance, and financial struggles
  - Some other papers and longitudinal surveys find financial situation significant when measured certain ways.
- Separate myopia (personality trait) from need for money now (financial situation)
- Ask about policy variations
  - To single out preference for ex-ante insurance vs ex-post redistribution.
- Tax incidence
  - Who, in the end, benefits from redistributive taxes or higher taxes?

- Post-materialism
    - climaterisk could be capturing a latent worldview/ideology (prioritizing goals other than economic growth)
- Visual tax proposal without experimental variation
    - Our current experimental variation introduces noise in the regressions